

Operations in Partapur Sector

(1971 Indo-Pak War)

These operations took place along the Shyok river at heights of more than 18,000 ft. with a total force of three Ladakh Scout companies supported by 500 hastily raised local militia called Nubra Guards. The Indian attack was led by Major Chewang Rinchen (*top*), who had earlier earned an MVC in the 1947 war and a Sena Medal in the 1962 war. Starting on December 8, this force advanced 22 km up to Thang village, including the capture of Point 18402, the highest post ever captured till then. At a cost of three wounded by enemy action and 45 casualties due to frostbite, Maj. Rinchen had liberated 800 sq. km from PoK (the largest area captured in the '71 operations). The strategic value of this was realised after the Indian Army occupied the Saltoro Range overlooking the Siachen Glacier in 1984. The areas captured in 1971 provided a secure southern flank that strengthened India's defensive positions along the Saltoro.

Operation Meghdoot, *1984*

On April 13, 1984, Captain Sanjay Kulkarni and 28 soldiers of 4 Kumaon were heli-landed at Bilafond La on the Saltoro range. Three days later, another group of Ladakh Scouts landed at Sia La. Thus began India's physical occupation of what is commonly called the Siachen sector. In life-threatening conditions and at an enormous human cost, the Indian Army has continued to hold this area. There are divergent views on the strategic importance of Siachen. Many dismiss the idea of large-scale operations in this area as far-fetched, while others point out that any direct military collusion between China and Pakistan can occur only in this sector. Whatever the merits of these arguments, it is evident that Siachen presents an indomitable frontier of India's territorial control.



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

Battle of Tololing

Kargil War, 1999



On May 3, 1999, a local shepherd reported the presence of Pakistani soldiers who had infiltrated the Kargil sector. Over the next week, multiple intrusions were reported across the sector—Pakistan had established around 130 posts across the LoC. The Pakistani aim was to cut off National Highway 1A that passes over Zoji La to Leh, hoping it would pressurise India to vacate the Siachen Glacier. Dominating NH1A at Dras is the 16,000 feet high Tololing feature from where Pakistani soldiers could interdict all movement. The battle for Tololing commenced on May 23 and, over the next 20 days, there was an intense fight, often at a distance of a few metres, as 18 Grenadiers attempted to dislodge the enemy from their entrenched positions. Tololing was captured on June 13. This first decisive victory proved to be the turning point of the Kargil War.